

# From Micro-Failure Tags to Defensive Syndromes: A Technical Framework for the Core Six User-Facing Failure Modes in AI Assistants

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**Date:** April 5, 2026  
**DOI:** <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19423182>  
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**Version:** 2.1.6 (Authoritative Long Version)

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## About This Paper

This paper addresses a structural vocabulary mismatch at the center of AI evaluation: technical teams use granular micro-failure tags precise enough to debug from but opaque for organizational governance, while governance stakeholders use experiential language accurate enough to describe real harm but non-actionable for engineering. This framework introduces a translation layer between them.

The Core Six AI Defensive Behavior Syndromes are six behaviorally coherent, user-facing failure modes -- Plausible Helpfulness, Built-Not-Connected, Hollow Completions, Capability Masking, Responsibility Diffusion, and Surface Compliance -- each defined with dual-lens profiles mapping bidirectionally to and from a set of 44 micro-failure tags drawn from existing evaluation literature.

The framework is grounded in the Breaking Through study: eighteen months of continuous practitioner immersion across multiple commercial AI systems, yielding a corpus of over 100 documented failure episodes from naturalistic development workflows (n=105 collected; n=45 with complete syndrome coding at publication). Syndrome categories were derived through a two-phase hybrid methodology combining emergent observational coding with confirmatory cross-taxonomy mapping. Operational artifacts accompanying the framework include evaluation dashboard designs, incident report templates, model card enhancements, and procurement language enabling adoption without replacing existing evaluation infrastructure.

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## Repository Contents

### Primary Documents

| File                                                             | Description                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-final.pdf | Final published document - The publicly released version, suitable for citation and distribution. |

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 02-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-final.docx | Formatted document - Markdown content rendered with YIM Research Paper typographic styles, suitable for print and formal submission. |
| 03-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-final.md   | Primary document - Markdown format with named figure references and captions. Readable directly on GitHub.                           |

## Supplementary Materials

| File                                                                               | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 04-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-Supplementary-Materials.pdf | Operational artifacts accompanying the Core Six framework: evaluation dashboard designs, incident report templates, model card enhancement language, and procurement criteria. Intended for practitioners and governance teams adopting the framework. |

## Audit Trail

| File                                                                    | Description                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 06-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-(audit trail).md | Full development audit trail - A complete session-by-session record of every significant edit, directive, source check, and version change from v1.0 to v2.1.6. Includes file manifest with SHA256 hashes for locally archived files. |

## Verification and Integrity

| File                                                                                      | Description                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 07-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-(Public-Verification-Appendix).pdf | Public verification appendix - Full source registry documenting every claim in the paper with its evidentiary basis, source traceability, and verification status.                                 |
| 08-FromMicroFailuresToDefensiveSyndromes(LONG-VERSION)-(Verification-Report).pdf          | Verification report - An independently conducted claim-by-claim review documenting what was examined, what evidence was consulted, and the verification status of assertions throughout the paper. |

## Images

The images/ subfolder contains the 23 figures referenced in the primary document:

- core-six-cover.png - Cover image
  - core-six-a.png, core-six-b.png - Framework overview diagrams
  - core-six-figure-1.png through core-six-figure-21.jpg - In-document figures (23 total)
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## Integrity Verification

**The audit trail document** (06-...(audit trail).md) contains a File Manifest table listing every file in this release package with SHA256 hash values for locally archived files. External published sources accessed via DOI are noted as "N/A - external source" in the manifest; their integrity is established by the DOI link to the publisher's record.

**The Zenodo archive** at [10.5281/zenodo.19423182](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19423182) provides an independent, timestamped, permanent record of the same files. The Zenodo record serves as the authoritative published snapshot; any discrepancy between files in this repository and the Zenodo archive should be treated as a flag for review.

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## How to Cite

Taylor, E. A. (2026). *From Micro-Failure Tags to Defensive Syndromes: A Technical Framework for the Core Six User-Facing Failure Modes in AI Assistants* (v2.1.6). YIM Project. DOI: [10.5281/zenodo.19423182](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19423182)

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